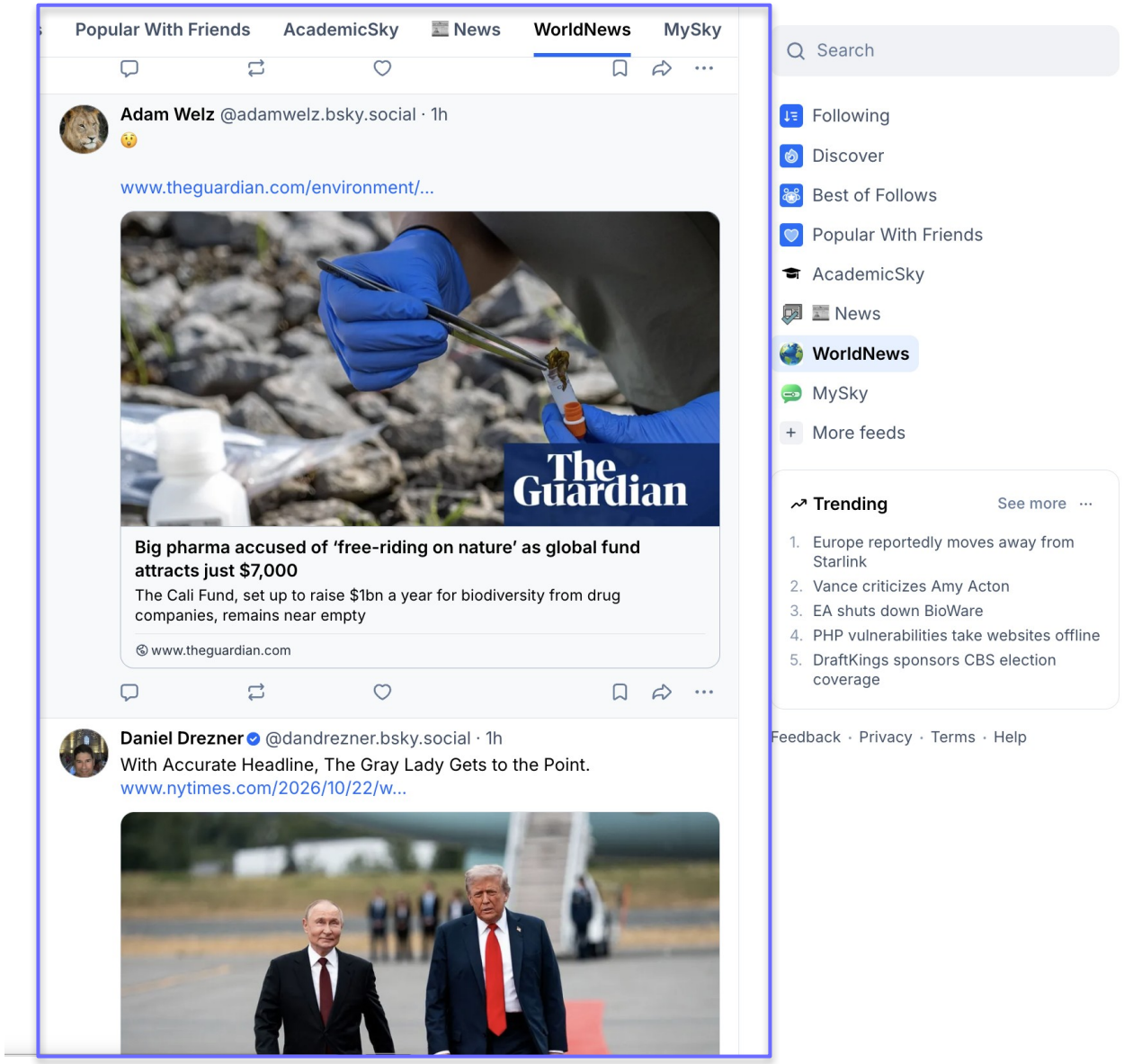
Intro to Algorithmically Curated Feeds

Bao T. Truong • 22.10.2026

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Curation is how sites decide which posts goes in the feed and in what order they're displayed



An example of a feed on Bluesky

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Objectives

- Explain the basic stages of an algorithmically curated feed
- Apply simple filtering and scoring rules to select and order posts
- Understand how practical constraints and design choices influence what users see.
- Start thinking about a modification to the pipeline and formulate a testable hypothesis about its consequences.

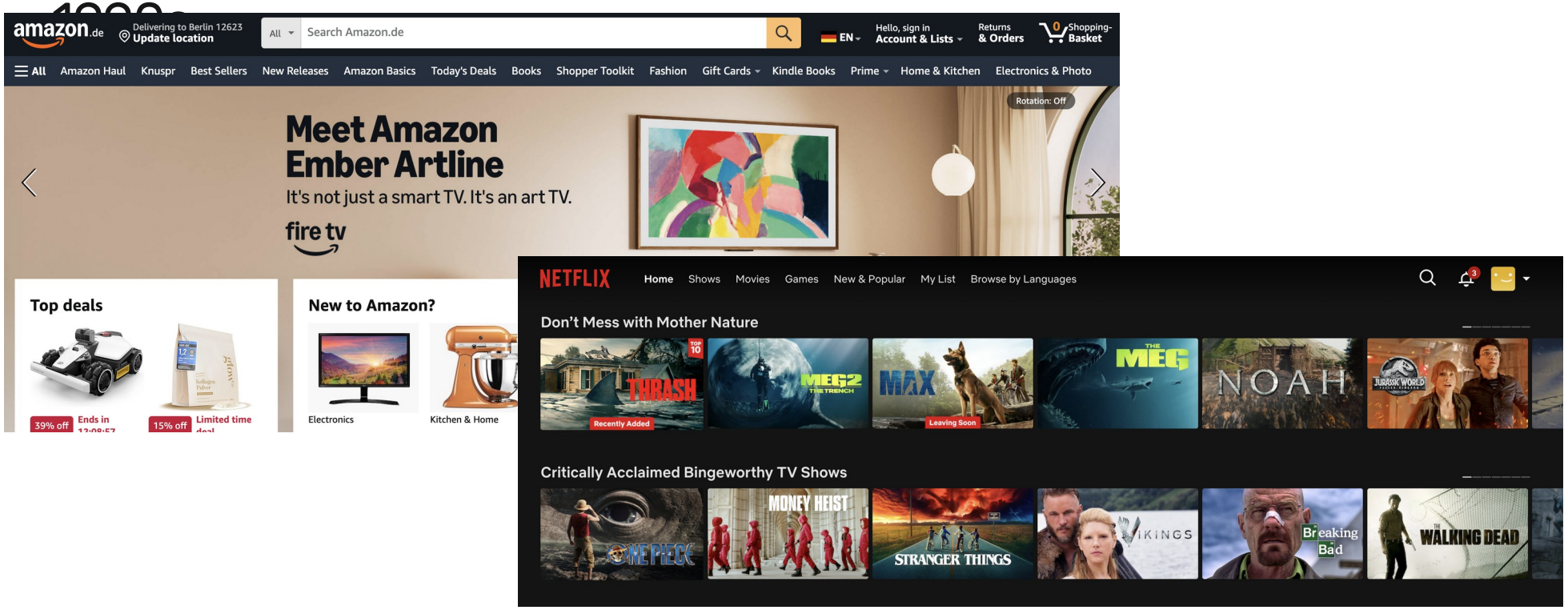
Why do we need curation?

- Helps users find relevant items when there are too many choices
- Reduce information overload and support decision-making

- Inspired by social navigation – sharing knowledge to guide others
  - Ants leave trails → guide others to food
  - Humans rely on others' experiences (e.g., trying food, critics)

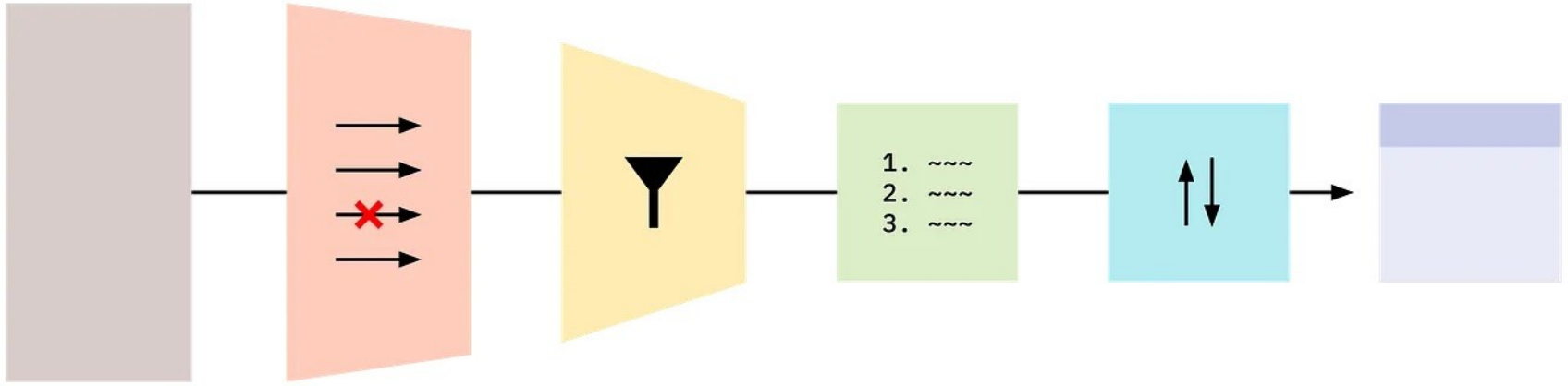
Curation is built on recommender systems

- Recommender systems became widespread in the mid–late



A typical algorithmic curation pipeline includes Retrieval + Ranking

Retrieval



Surface desirable candidates

[How Platform Recommenders Work]

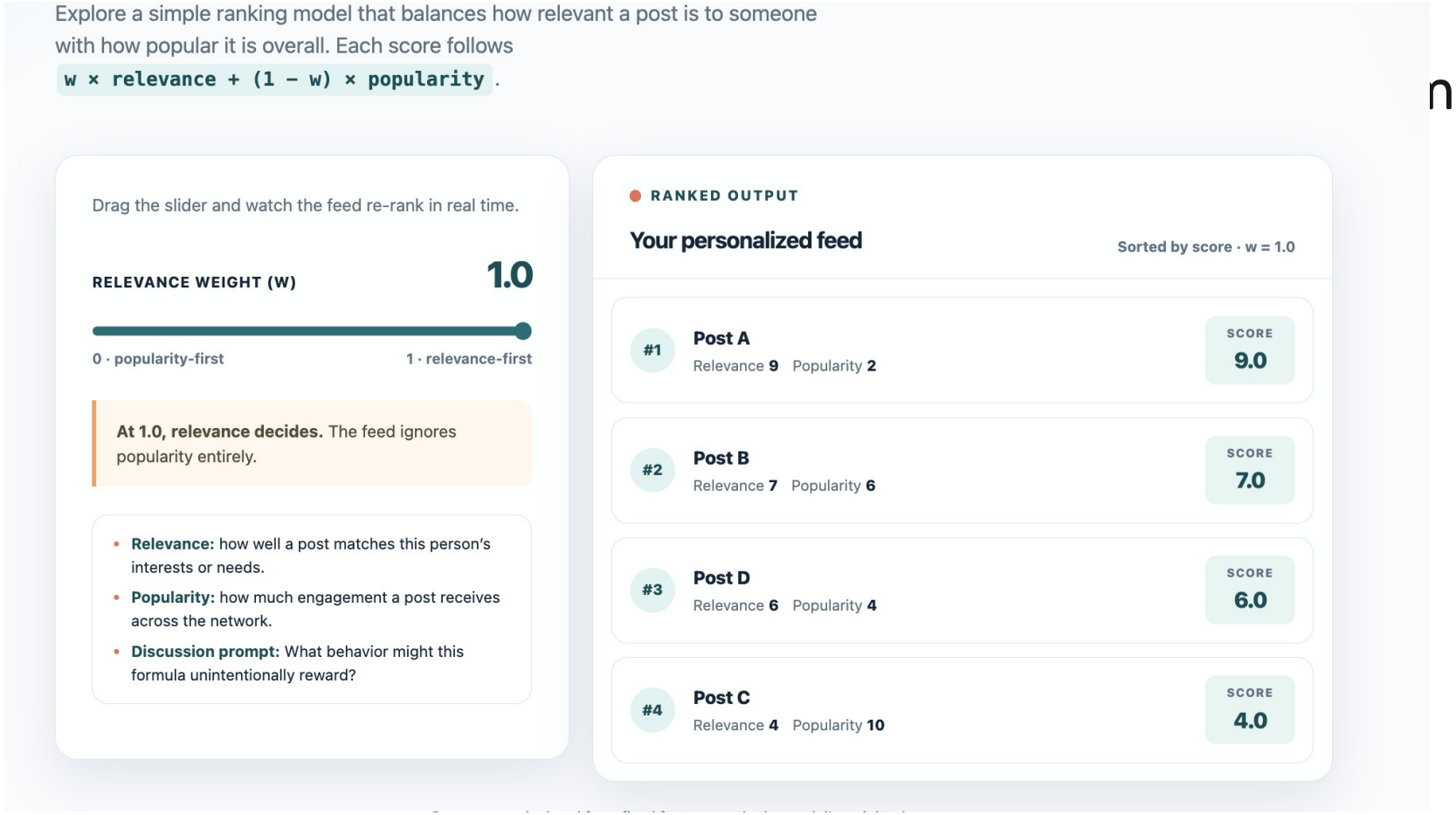
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Algorithmic curation

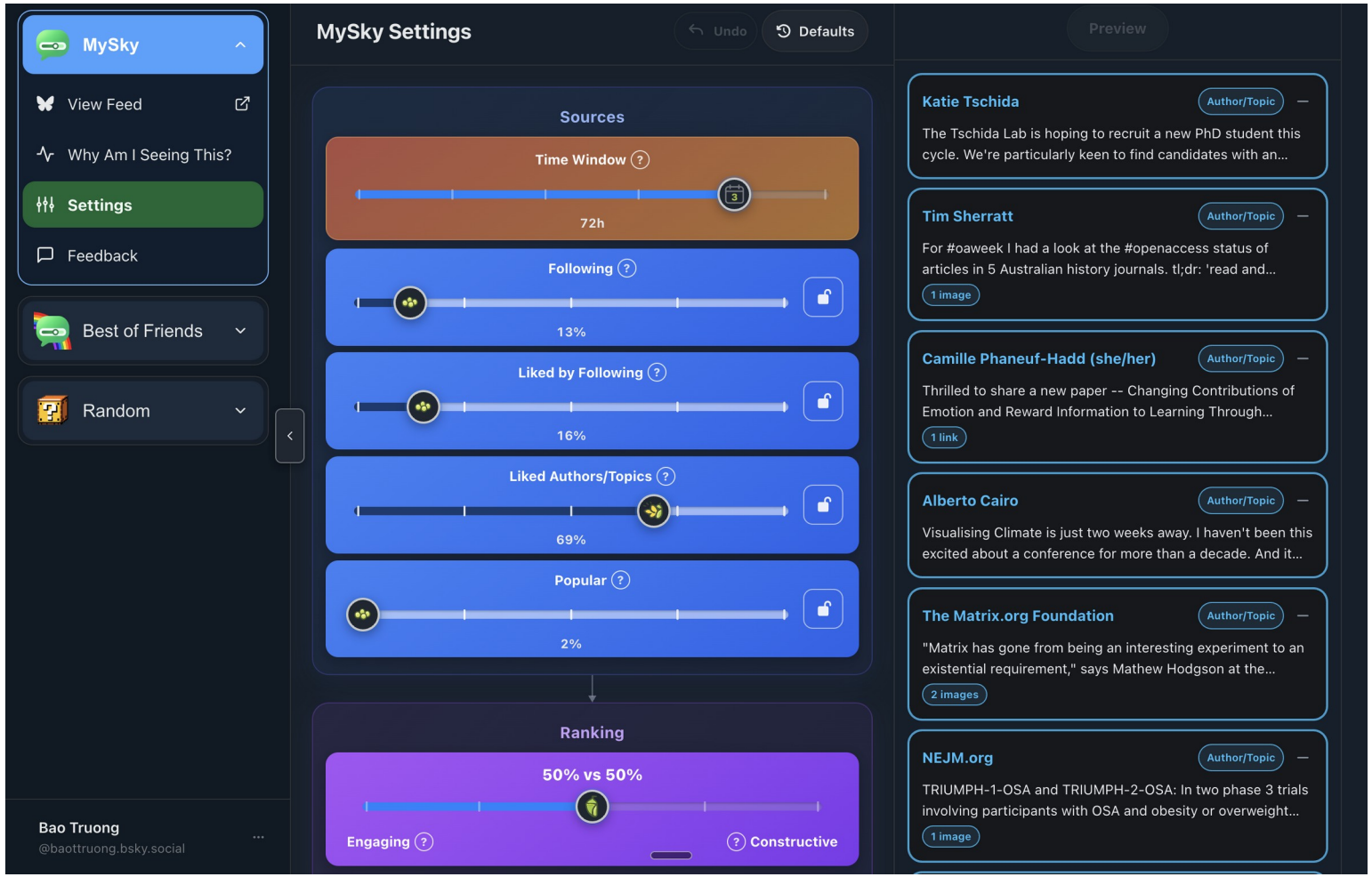
- Recommender systems are part of algorithmic curation. However, the goals and means of algorithmic curation are broader.
- It aims to select and organize content for display
- To do this the means are:
- Filtering
- Moderation
- Ranking

Explore a ranking example



Click on the link to explore interactively

Explore a customized feed



Click on the link to explore interactively

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Homework : Redesign a Social Media Feed

- **Objective:** Explore how algorithmic design choices can shape users' experiences on social media. This exercise is meant to get you started on brainstorming ideas for an experiment. Focus on making your proposed modification concrete and explaining its potential consequences.
- Visit Prosocial Design and explore its proposed interventions. Choose one intervention that interests you, then complete the following tasks:
- Briefly describe the intervention, the problem it addresses, and its proposed solution.
- Propose your own modification to a social media feed, inspired by the intervention or your own ideas. Identify which stage of the curation pipeline you would modify (retrieval, scoring, ranking, or presentation) and explain how.
- Reflect. Discuss one potential benefit and one possible drawback of your modification. Propose one research question that could be investigated experimentally.
- **Submission:** A short written response (300–400 words) as prompt to discuss in class.

Homework, optional

- Read the primers from Prosocial Design
- Read Understanding Social Media Recommendation Algorithms (Narayanan, 2023)